EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

# What Did Moshe See When He Saw God's Back?

**Given Monday 15 July 2024** · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:12

**Sefer:** Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 2, Chapter 12 (the last two categories: action, and being acted upon), with the opening of Chapter 13 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 15 July 2024, on Zoom

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Recap

We are going through the **ten anthropomorphisms** in the Torah. Last week, in Chapter 11, we covered feelings, relation, place, time, possession and position. Chapter 12 deals with the final two:

| Part | Category |
|---|---|
| 1 | **Action** (*po'el*): Hashem doing things |
| 2 | **Being acted upon** (*nif'al*): Hashem as the recipient of action |

## 9. Action: Hashem Does Not "Do"

Even though the Torah speaks of Hashem doing this or that, we cannot take it literally. Rav Saadia gives two reasons:

1. **A physical agent must act in order to affect something else.** This is an Aristotelian idea: nothing physical can affect another physical thing unless it does something itself. If you want to move something by blowing on it, you have to blow. "But the way of Hashem is, He just wishes, and things happen." When we say Hashem did something, it means **He willed it, and it came to be**.
2. **A physical agent needs material, time and space** to act. That is inappropriate to say of Hashem.

### Doing and stopping

The Torah describes both Hashem acting and Hashem ceasing to act, and both mean the same kind of thing:

| Action | Its opposite | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| **Creation**: Hashem "made" | **וישבת ביום השביעי**, "and He rested on the seventh day" (Bereishit 2:2) | He created through **will and desire**. "He rested" does not mean He rested from work. It means His will to create **stopped**: "no more creating" |
| **Prophecy**: "Hashem spoke" to Moshe, to Aharon | **החשיתי מעולם... אתאפק**, "I have long kept silent, I have restrained Myself" (Yeshayahu 42:14) | "Hashem spoke" means He **created speech** that reached the prophet's ears. God has no voice and no sound waves. "I kept silent" means He stopped that created communication and was waiting, patient |

## The Mutakallimun

Why does Rav Saadia stress the *opposite* of speech? Because the Arab philosophers, the **Mutakallimun**, held the same idea of created speech but did **not** accept that it could stop. The Rabbi explained their name: *kalam* is Arabic for "word", from the same idea as *medaber*, to speak. They held that creation is constantly sustained by Hashem's **constant speech**, so to say that Hashem stops speaking was unacceptable to them.

We too say that Hashem constantly renews creation, **המחדש בטובו בכל יום תמיד מעשה בראשית**, but not through ongoing speech. The Torah shows us both the act and its opposite: He created and He rested, He spoke and He stopped speaking.

## Creating versus sustaining

A participant asked: if Hashem stopped creating, what of *ratzo vashov*, the constant "running and returning" that keeps the world going? The Rabbi offered a parable he has given before:

Close your eyes and create in your mind the most beautiful universe you could wish to live in. Spend half an hour focusing on it, meditating on it. Then someone calls your name, and that universe is gone from your mind. The half-hour of creating it, that was *vaya'as*, the doing. Now, if you simply keep holding it in your mind, that is *mechadesh betuvo*, the constant renewal.

So the maintenance of the world came from an initial act, and then *vayishbot*, He stopped actively creating. Of course He sustains it, but sustaining is different from creating. "You might not speak, but you're constantly thinking about it." The participant added: "The moment you stop, it's cut off." "Precisely. Very good."

## Remembering, but never forgetting

When Hashem rescues people from difficulty, the Torah calls it **remembering**: **ויזכר אלהים את נח**, "God remembered Noach" (Bereishit 8:1), and **ויזכר אלהים את רחל**, "God remembered Rachel" (Bereishit 30:22). It means He now intervenes to help.

The Rabbi pointed out something interesting. Unlike "made and rested" or "spoke and kept silent," **we never find the opposite**, that Hashem *forgot*. Theoretically one could say "Hashem forgot," meaning He no longer helps. What we do find is that He **did not remember**: **ולא זכר הדום רגליו**, He did not remember His footstool, the Beit HaMikdash, and allowed it to be destroyed (Eicha 2:1).

### The attributes are all in reference to us

Finally: when Hashem acts with mercy, we call Him **merciful and compassionate**. When He exacts punishment, He is **אל נקמות**, the God of vengeance. **שומר הברית והחסד**, "He keeps the covenant and kindness," for His people. All these terms refer **only to creatures**, to us.

"This is the first person to say this. This is a fundamental principle which we're going to develop. He is the first one to explicitly come up with this concept: that all attributes of Hashem are only in reference to His creatures."

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## Two Kinds of Names: Essence and Action

From this the Rabbi developed the distinction that grows out of Rav Saadia's principle:

| | **Names of action (*shemot hape'ulot*)** | **Names of essence (*shemot ha'etzem*)** |
|---|---|---|
| **Examples** | Compassionate, gracious, kind, slow to anger, vengeful, zealous | One, eternal (*Kadmon*), wise |
| **When** | Only after creation: they need a world to act upon | True whether or not there is a world |
| **How understood** | Positively, but only as **perceived by us**. "When we say on Yom Kippur over and over again *Rachum veChanun, Erech Apayim*, there's no such thing as Hashem slow to anger. It's just how it's perceived to us" | **Only negatively**. And all of them are one; they are not parts of Hashem |

As he said in Chapters 8 and 9, all these names are from our perspective, and Hashem remains one entity. "This is critical to understand."

### The Rambam: negative theology

The Rabbi read from the **Moreh Nevuchim, Part 1, Chapter 59**. The Rambam has rejected all positive attributes. We can only know what Hashem is **not**: "Hashem is one" means He is not two. "Hashem is eternal" means He has no beginning or end. A person may then ask: if everything is negative, and once I have proven the negative that is it, what advantage did **Moshe** have over anyone else?

The Rambam answers: there is indeed a huge difference. Just as each additional positive attribute specifies an object more and brings you nearer to it, so **each additional negation brings you nearer** to understanding HaKadosh Baruch Hu. The more you negate, the more you understand.

So, the Rabbi explained, even Rav Saadia's *names of essence* are not ways to understand Hashem positively. They describe what He is not.

### Rabbeinu Bachya and Rav Yosef Albo

**Rabbeinu Bachya** (in Chovot HaLevavot) follows Rav Saadia. He divides Hashem's names into **essential** and **active**. Essential names are those that applied before there were any creations. Active names, such as "compassionate", come after creation: whenever there are two, it is a

name of action. And even the essential names are all one, with no diversity. The key lines: whenever you speak of attributes, understand them as **negating the opposite**. "Negating the attributes of Hashem gives us a better understanding of Hashem than affirming His attributes," and the more we negate, the deeper our understanding of His unity. Rabbeinu Bachya says he will not elaborate, since Rav Saadia already did. "It all started here," the Rabbi said. "This is the source of this concept," found in all the Sephardi medieval philosophers.

**Rav Yosef Albo** makes a sweeping statement:

> **כל בעלי העיון הפילוסופי חושבים שאי אפשר לייחס לשם יתברך שום תואר, לא עצמי ולא מקרי מצד עצמו... אלא שוללי, ושכל התארים השוללים צודקים עליו**
> All philosophers hold that one cannot ascribe to Hashem any attribute, essential or accidental, in Himself... only negative ones, and all negative attributes are true of Him.

But with regard to His **actions**, we can speak positively, because those relate to us as humans.

## "Is everyone with me?"

The Rabbi checked that the class understood, and when someone said "more or less," he replied that "more or less" was not good enough. "This is really the basis of medieval Jewish philosophy." He repeated it:

- **Names of action**, such as compassionate, kind, slow to anger, vengeful, describe how Hashem's conduct is **perceived by us**.
- **Names of essence**, such as one, eternal, wise, existed before humans. Hashem is infinite, and "you cannot understand what *one* means in infinity, or *eternal*, or *wise*, because that wisdom is infinite wisdom." All you can properly grasp is the negation: Hashem is **not not-wise**.

Or, in the image he has used before: the *Or Ein Sof* and the sunglasses we wear to perceive the light. The names of action describe the light as we see it through our glasses.

## The Ramchal builds on this

"By the way, I'll quickly throw in, the whole philosophy of the Ramchal is based on this." In **Derech Hashem** and **Da'at Tevunot**, the whole of creation depends on **Yichud Hashem**. Why? Because unity is **the only thing the human mind can fully understand** about Hashem. We cannot understand His wisdom or compassion in His essence. We can only arrive at negation, and the one negation we can fully grasp is that **there is no other force but Hashem**. "Hashem Echad means there are not two. That's possible for us to gain a full understanding of."

The Rabbi recalled that the Ramchal never quotes anyone except Chazal, with one exception: the Rambam, and he quotes exactly this passage on negative theology, on which he builds his whole philosophy of Yichud Hashem.

A participant asked why the infinite needs any "definition" at all, even negative. "For us, correct," said the Rabbi. The distinction is only for our purposes: names of action we can understand in some positive sense, for the creatures. Names of essence we will never understand positively.

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## 10. Being Acted Upon: Can Hashem Be Seen?

The tenth category is Hashem as a **recipient**. Nobody really thinks Hashem can receive anything: money, a bribe, a gift. We all accept that, since He is not physical.

But people do think Hashem can be the "recipient" of **sight**, that you could see Him. Rav Saadia makes clear that this is impossible. Things are seen through physical media, through the air and the eye. And he adds:

We cannot even properly **think** about Hashem. How then would you see Him, if you can barely conceive of Him?

### The elephant in the room

Then comes the big problem: Moshe on Sinai after the golden calf.

**הראני נא את כבדך** Show me, please, Your glory. (Shemot 33:18)

**לא תוכל לראת את פני, כי לא יראני האדם וחי** You cannot see My face, for no man can see Me and live. (33:20)

**ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי. והסרתי את כפי וראית את אחרי, ופני לא יראו** I will cover you with My palm until I pass. Then I will remove My palm, and you will see My back, but My face will not be seen. (33:22-23)

"What on earth is going on here?" (The Rabbi noted that the verse speaks of Hashem's *palm*, not a tallit. That image comes from the Gemara, which is a separate matter.) We have just established that one cannot see Hashem. How will Rav Saadia answer?

### Rav Saadia: the front and back of the created light

He answers from what we learned in Chapter 10 about the prophets' visions. Hashem creates an image, called the **Kavod Hashem**. Moshe was asking: **show me the Kavod**, this amazing image You create.

Hashem answers: I will show you. But know that the other prophets only see a kind of reflection of this image. You cannot see it in full from its beginning, because the beginning is too intense. Let it recede and dilute a little, and then you can see it. That is "seeing My back." I will cover you, block your eyes, so that you do not see the beginning of this powerful image, and then you will see its back.

Rav Saadia explains further: Hashem creates a special light and shows it to the prophets. When they see it, they say "I saw the glory of God," and sometimes simply "I saw Hashem," leaving words out (*derech chisaron*). His proof: about the elders at Sinai it says **ויראו את אלהי ישראל**, "they saw the God of Israel" (Shemot 24:10), and a few verses later **ומראה כבוד ה׳**, "the appearance of the **glory** of Hashem" (24:17). And **Targum Onkelos** and **Targum Yonatan** already translate the first as **וחזו ית יקר אלהא דישראל**, "they saw the **glory** of the God of Israel."

Even the prophets cannot look at this light directly; they see diluted reflections. Moshe felt this was his opportunity to see the light itself. Hashem said: its beginning is too much. I will cover you with My "palm," which is the **cloud of glory**, a blindfold if you like, until the intense beginning passes. Then I will remove it and you will see the **back**: the less intense part of the vision. But seeing God Himself is impossible.

The Rabbi noted that **Ibn Ezra** says something similar in his commentary on Iyov, explaining the covering as a kind of cloud that envelops the person, and that **Rabbeinu Bachya** also took on Rav Saadia's concept of the created glory.

A participant connected this to the **mirrors**: the other prophets see through many mirrors, while Moshe sees the actual image, but even that, not at its most intense. "That fits very nicely with *panai* and *achorai*," said another: the intensity at the beginning and the receding at the end.

### The Rambam

The Rambam in the Moreh says that all these visions are **deep intellectual understanding**, not physical sight. But, the Rabbi read, the Rambam then adds that if someone finds it hard to understand what it means to "see" God intellectually, and wants to read it more literally, he may take it as seeing with the eyes, as long as what he sees is a **created** light and not God. "He doesn't say Saadia, but he's referring to that. That's not what I believe it means, but that's acceptable. I won't criticise you for understanding that."

### Three interpretations

| | What is "front" and "back"? |
|---|---|
| **Rav Saadia** | The front and back of the **created image**. Moshe saw the less intense part of the Kavod, in his mind but as a real vision |
| **The Rambam** | **Depth of understanding**. "Front" is the deepest understanding of Hashem, beyond any human. "Back" is the most a human can reach, which Moshe attained. There is no image at all |
| **Some Ba'alei HaTosafot** | Read it literally: a front and back of Hashem passing by. (Rejected) |

**Richard** had made the point last week that Rav Saadia's "seeing" is still in the mind. "You're right," said the Rabbi. It is a seeing in the prophet's consciousness, a spiritual creation, a special vision. "Even the greatest prophet is not seeing anything physically which you can touch. But in your mind you have this very physical manifestation of this creation."

**Marie** asked what front and back mean at all. A participant suggested each person has a different limit to his mind, and Moshe was the least limited. "Everything you've said so far is correct," said the Rabbi. The question is only whether Hashem was giving Moshe a deep understanding (the Rambam) or showing him a vision and its less intense part (Rav Saadia).

Several participants felt Rav Saadia's reading fits the text better. The Rabbi agreed:

"Saadia's interpretation is much clearer and much more understandable in the text, whereas the Rambam's is very floppy: front and back are just ways to describe deeper or less deep understanding. Saadia is beautiful. The front of the image, the very intense part, I can't show you. But I can show you the back of the image, the Kavod Hashem. It's a much better interpretation."

And it explains **panim el panim**, "face to face," with Moshe: a more direct, clearer, more intense vision. *Panim* always refers to the more direct.

**Chaim**'s takeaway: the moment you give any option of seeing Hashem, you reduce Him. "Exactly. That's the key takeaway."

### Once more, the Kabbalah

The Rabbi again saw a parallel with the Kabbalah. All the Sefirot go back to the **Or Ein Sof**, but the Kabbalists stress that the Or Ein Sof is not Hashem Himself. It is an emanation. Each of the ten Sefirot contains ten Sefirot, so perhaps Moshe reached the top Sefirah but not its own highest point, its "back" rather than its *keter*. Richard asked whether this was forcing the Kabbalah. The Rabbi linked it to the **Or HaGanuz**, the hidden light: had we stayed in Gan Eden we would understand this light far more, and **Olam HaBa** means understanding HaKadosh Baruch Hu. "But even in Olam HaBa, you're never going to understand Hashem Himself. Closer, but of course, it's impossible. That's our definition of God."

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## Chapter 13: Final Questions

With fifteen minutes left, the Rabbi began the last chapter of the essay, with a word of encouragement for anyone who had found Essay 2 too difficult. "When we start in September it gets much easier. It's still a philosophical book, but it'll be more practical. Please don't become disillusioned."

Chapter 13 has a few final questions and then "a beautiful essay, really beautiful, on the love of Hashem," which he believes the Rambam drew on.

### Question 1: How can we know something non-physical?

If Hashem has nothing physical, how can we perceive Him at all? Rav Saadia's answer: we all understand and accept that **lying is bad and truth is good**. Have you ever touched that? We understand that something cannot be present and not present at the same time, and other impossibilities. We have never seen these, yet we know them to be true. In the same way, though we cannot see Hashem, we can understand Him as far as possible.

A participant objected that "lying is bad" might be a social construct, learned from experience because lying leads to bad outcomes, and the same might be said of logical impossibilities. "It's a fair point," said the Rabbi. "I don't think we're able to prove that either way."

### Question 2: How can Hashem be everywhere?

"This is going to be a *machloket* between the Chassidim and the Ashkenazim as well, the Gra and the Ba'al HaTanya." How can we say there is nowhere without Hashem, when there is a world here? The Rabbi noted that the song "Hashem is here, Hashem is there, Hashem is truly everywhere" represents **only one opinion** in Jewish theology, the Lubavitch one, not that of the Gra.

Rav Saadia answers: Hashem existed before there was any space, as discussed in Chapter 11. If creating physical things caused any division or gap in Him, He would not have created them. His presence after creation is exactly as it was before, without any effect, as the verse says, **הלא את השמים ואת הארץ אני מלא**, "Do I not fill heaven and earth?" (Yirmiyahu 23:24). "We can't get

our heads around it, because we think: my body is here, this earth is here, so where does Hashem go in all of that? But from Hashem's perspective, it's all the same."

His examples: some walls do not stop **sound**. **Glass** does not stop light. **Sunlight** is not affected by all the dirt in the world. Physical things can exist without affecting what passes through them. "I don't really think they are marvels nowadays, science has shown us how these things work," but that is how Rav Saadia illustrates it.

### Shir HaYichud

The Rabbi asked whether anyone knew **Shir HaYichud**. Its author is uncertain, but some believe it was Rav Saadia. In Europe some would say it at the end of every Shacharit, a song for each day of the week, and the Mishnah Berurah quotes it. Few communities say it daily now, but many Ashkenazi communities still say it on the night of Yom Kippur.

He read from the song for Tuesday, and asked the class whether it sounded familiar: **all the walls cannot divide You; the dirt does not soil You; You are in everything**. These are the very examples Rav Saadia gave: sound through walls, light through glass, the sun untouched by dirt. "So some believed that this was written by Rav Saadia. The whole thing is about Hashem being everywhere."

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## Summary

1. **Action:** Hashem does not act physically. "He made" means He willed. "He rested" means His will to create stopped. "He spoke" means He created speech. "I kept silent" means He stopped it. Against the Mutakallimun, created speech can cease.
2. **Creating and sustaining** differ, like imagining a universe and then simply holding it in mind.
3. Hashem "remembers," but the Torah never says He **forgets**, only that He "did not remember."
4. **All attributes of action** (merciful, gracious, vengeful) refer only to creatures. Rav Saadia is the first to say so explicitly.
5. **Names of essence** (one, eternal, wise) can only be understood negatively and are all one: the Rambam's negative theology, Rabbeinu Bachya, Rav Yosef Albo, and the foundation of the Ramchal's Yichud Hashem.
6. **Being acted upon:** Hashem receives nothing, including sight. We can barely think of Him, let alone see Him.
7. **"You will see My back":** for Rav Saadia, Moshe saw the less intense part of the created **Kavod**, after Hashem shielded him from its intense beginning with a cloud. For the Rambam, front and back are degrees of understanding. The Rabbi found Rav Saadia's reading clearer and better.
8. **Chapter 13:** we know non-physical truths like honesty and logical impossibility, so we can know Hashem. And creation does not divide Hashem's presence, like sound through walls and light through glass, as the **Shir HaYichud** puts it.

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## Coming Up

Next Monday, the last shiur before the summer break:

- A fascinating **teshuvah of the Maharshal** about those who did not want to say Shir HaYichud.
- How this relates to the dispute between the **Vilna Gaon and the Ba'al HaTanya** on Hashem's presence in the world.
- Rav Saadia's essay on the **love of Hashem**.
- A theological question Rav Saadia is the first to raise: **can Hashem do the impossible?**

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